

## eg update

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### 【要点】

- ・グローバル化は経済効率性と人間開発の進展をもたらしたが、地政学的な不安定性と政治的干渉により、国際的なサプライチェーンと知識経済は分断化ヘシフトしている。
- ・地政学的後退の時代では、国際ルールと力の均衡がズレており、多国間機関の指導力不足が生じ、台湾の半導体、ロシアのエネルギー、中国のレアアース、中東の石油など戦略的に重要な産業が地政学的リスクにさらされている。
- ・各地域の経済的利益は大きいですが、主権争いやエネルギー戦争など政治的リスクが経営モデルに支障をきたし、企業は短期的なコスト増加を覚悟で耐性強化ヘシフトする必要がある。
- ・グローバル化による全体的な富の増加が、労働者階級と中産階級の所得減少につながり、富の分配不均等が社会的課題となっている。

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### 【メール原文】

dear hondo-san,

a world turning away from globalization. more donroe doctrine. the us supreme court. and a quick note on iran.

globalization's discontents

there are all sorts of reasons to believe in the continued prospects of goods and services, people and ideas moving faster and faster around the world. globalization is economically efficient and has driven the greatest period of largely uninterrupted growth and human development that we've ever seen—measured in overall gdp, in productivity, in consumption, in education rates, and in health and life expectancy, just to name a few. and the world is only getting smaller...with new technologies having more immediate and global impact, and eight billion people on the planet becoming far more interconnected and interdependent (whether they know it or not).

and yet, the system of just-in-time global supply chains for manufactured goods and a globally integrated knowledge economy for services is shifting toward greater fragmentation. there are lots of reasons for that, which are only loosely related. it's worth looking at them together.

1) geopolitical recession. the g-zero world reflects a period of misalignment between the international rules of the road and the underlying balance of power. the opposite of a geopolitical boom cycle (when a country or set of countries set priorities and promote architecture that most governments see as legitimate and worthy of support), in a geopolitical recession there's an absence of leadership for multilateral institutions and rule of law. which provides more space for unilateralism—whether by major powers, rogue states, or countries in between with the ability to hedge. all of which creates problems for business models predicated on international political cooperation and, accordingly, globalization.

and so there are lots of places where the economics make great sense for business, until politics interferes: 1) a near-monopoly of global semiconductor production in taiwan, 100 miles off the shore of

mainland china...now threatened by contested sovereignty from beijing; 2) cheap oil and gas from russia powering the european continent...before the ukraine war; 3) global critical minerals production, supply chains and processing dominated by china...until they impose a licensing regime in response to an effective us trade boycott; and 4) oil, lng, petrochemicals and more from the middle east...until the united states and israel launch decapitation strikes against iran and the iranians shut the strait of hormuz.

in each case, the geopolitical recession-induced political shock leads to decisions to increase resilience that prove costly in the short term...and which are ultimately more aligned with a fragmented and more uncertain global geopolitical order.

2) domestic politics. globalization creating more overall wealth doesn't mean more wealth for everyone. with distribution effects leading to the long-discussed "hollowing out" of working and middle classes. this was the principal thesis of thomas piketty's "capital" back in 2013 (as well as branko milanovic's famous "elephant chart" depicting changes in global distribution) as applied to the rank and file labor force of the advanced industrial economies...who were abundantly substitutable as the top 10% of global earners by cheaper productive labor in the developing world. and it's the difference between the macro benefits from globalization, and the presumption from advocates of globalism that a hands-off approach from governments would ultimately be best for everyone.

this has had greatest direct impact in the politics of the united states, the world's driver of globalization, where over time popular support for free trade has dramatically decreased. the leader of global capitalism now sees the democratic socialists as the political force with the greatest momentum among the country's young voters. political leaders find the domestic working and middle classes want subsidies, industrial policy and protectionism. the us "liberation day" tariffs were the most dramatic piece of this—setting the highest tariffs the world has seen from the united states in nearly a century. which leads to other countries pushing to protect their own industries and labor forces even further in response.

3) changing role of labor. access to inexpensive labor has been one of the biggest drivers of globalization. opening up the chinese market, and the developing world more broadly, meant increased profitability for global manufacturers and, as the global economy advanced and free trade evolved up the value chain, services companies that relied on labor as a core component of their cost base. those investments then in turn raised incomes in the developing world, creating greater demand for goods and services globally.

as globalization progressed, labor cost differentials eventually became smaller, as capital investment increased demand for developing market labor and wages increased accordingly. growing demand also means more competition for that labor, making it harder to maintain a fixed labor force and driving up replacement costs. add to that technological advances in industrial automation and robotics, reducing the relevance of blue-collar labor to manufactured goods and driving up profitability to bring production centers closer to where business and consumer demand is.

that's set to shift further with artificial intelligence. with white-collar labor becoming more easily substituted, particularly at more junior levels. this puts a premium on the most expensive knowledge work (most of which currently takes place in higher-income markets), reducing the utility of investment in developing markets with lower-cost knowledge workers.

4) national security. the most advanced ai models are becoming too strategically important for governments to share or cede control. as artificial intelligence becomes essential in building tools that,

in the wrong hands, can act as weapons—bioweapons, lethal autonomous drone swarms, cyber hacking tools and the like—governments will increasingly treat advanced ai and components of the tech stack that supports it as essential for maintaining sovereignty, and accordingly more important than ai's positive-sum economic role in driving profitability.

this is not to take away from the importance of artificial intelligence in driving productivity and innovation across sectors, that's far from the case. but rather that the united states and china, with control of the most important models, will increasingly limit exposure to ai capabilities by competitors and adversaries. hence the recent "europe 2031" report argues that europe is in danger of becoming a satellite of the united states if they can't develop their own sovereign capability in the next five years (an unlikely prospect).

economically, this is a new dynamic. the arms race between the americans and the soviets during the cold war meant fundamental antagonism in nuclear build-up, but the knock-on economic importance was limited. an ai arms race between the americans and the chinese also necessarily means competition and increasing controls over the technology that simultaneously occupies the commanding heights of the global economy—and represents a core challenge to globalization. ultimately (say, over the next one to two decades), if an ai arms race continues (as now looks likely) and control over ai becomes the most important input to both geopolitical and economic strength, this is the trend that would most decisively undermine globalization.

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the most impactful macro trend i haven't included here is climate, because its core implications work at cross-purposes. on the one hand, the money being invested into post-carbon energy and the creation of electrostates (led by china, but coming soon everywhere) lead toward the globalization of new energy technologies at scale, reducing the importance of opec, transit bottlenecks, strategic stockpiling, and the like. on the other, climate change will cause the greatest economic damage in developing (not to mention many of the most populous) countries, which undermines their investblility and is a headwind to globalization trends.

but overall, the combination of political, economic, and technological drivers is now becoming significant as a counterbalance to what has otherwise been the strongest structural force driving the global economy for generations. none of these are permanent (indeed, the geopolitical and domestic political drivers are cyclical), but they've been building for decades now and are likely to remain features of the global economic landscape through at least two or three more electoral cycles.

us – latin america

lack of progress on a broader iran deal notwithstanding, the trump administration remains extremely eager to turn to the western hemisphere.

the big news remains venezuela, where the aftermath of a devastating earthquake is showing the limits of the delcy rodriguez administration to effectively handle a major crisis, with the united nations now estimating damages on the order of 40% (!) of gdp. that's both an opportunity and a danger for the americans. on the one hand, the acting venezuelan president needs help and the united states is uniquely positioned to make a difference—mobilizing a disaster assistance response team, search and rescue units, logistical support from southcom, as well as direct financial assistance and coordination with the imf, world bank, and the united nations. this increases the reliance of the new venezuelan government on the united states and gives the white house even more outsized influence on day-to-day

management of the country.

but delcy's ability to guarantee stability and continued foreign policy success for president trump is looking shakier, given the level of popular frustration, which will probably lead to an uptick in social unrest over time and add pressure for a political transition. in the near term, the trump administration is being cautious—opposition leader and nobel prize winner maria corina machado has been sidelined from the political process over the past months and has been planning to return to venezuela. she saw an opportunity with the earthquake to press her advantage...but was last week prevented from traveling by the venezuelan authorities (with support from the trump administration).

beyond venezuela, the trump administration is ramping up focus on using political leverage over leaders seen as involved with cartels. we're seeing that particularly in mexico, where the trump administration is now threatening to unseal indictments to embarrass president claudia sheinbaum if she doesn't take more aggressive action against corruption and address links to the cartels at the top of her morena party. the trump administration is also expanding scrutiny and direct sanctions on gang and cartel-related figures in brazil and across central america.

and then there's cuba. where a short period of trump optimism has now foundered on a view that recent economic reforms are limited, not the broader opening president trump is demanding from the communist government. they're now planning to escalate, though not through a direct military intervention. instead they're going after senior cuban officials' personal assets and looking at other avenues of economic pressure, while continuing to look for delcy-type figures who could play a more effective role in leading the economy of the country. there's no organized opposition movement (or credible leadership figure), but the white house continues to be optimistic, saying "yes, there are always people willing if the right incentives and disincentives are in place."

us judiciary

lots of rulings from the us supreme court last week—some favorable to trump, some unfavorable. the most meaningful is the slaughter decision, which overturns decades of precedent to allow the president to remove leaders in what previously had been "independent" agencies (though not the fed), treating the entire administrative state as subject to the direction and discretion of the president. that won't matter as much for the major agencies (ftc, fcc), which have de facto acted as partisan in behavior for some time; it's more of an issue for obscure agencies that have been more technocratic, where the policy pendulum will shift more, and faster, between administrations.

if there's potential for a real change, it would come from replacing sitting justices were they to retire. and the biggest impediment to confirming a replacement: president trump himself. trump isn't happy with all his first-term picks, each of whom has voted against various parts of the trump agenda in the court's current session. but if he insists on nominating a true loyalist, it's unlikely they would be able to secure the necessary fifty republican senate votes. it's also an important reason why justices samuel alito and clarence thomas (both well into their 70s) might not decide to retire this year, instead signing up for potentially another six years on the court if republicans lose the senate this fall: they would likely prefer their seats to be filled by serious judicial conservatives, not trump loyalists.

in short, the takeaways being that the court is undeniably conservative (as evidenced by the 6-3 lean on opinions reflecting that). but it also remains independent from president trump and as such one of many important structural reasons why a free and fair election in november and in 2028 remains a confident baseline assessment for the united states, trump's "political revolution" having failed.

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in iran, massive crowds for the funeral of supreme leader ali khamenei, reflecting a display of stability and strength for the iranian regime. the important story remains the rapid reopening of the strait, while both countries continue to mostly-observe an ongoing ceasefire. negotiations for any further agreement aren't moving, with fundamental us disagreements around ongoing payment to iran, and iranian disagreements around ongoing israeli occupation of southern lebanon. i fully expect more fighting to break out between israel and its various adversaries, including iran...but not a region-wide war that would drive a global recession or worse (which could have come if president trump had decided to make iran into a ground war to "take the oil," for example).

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in less pressing matters, disappointed to see president trump personally intervene with fifa leadership to overturn the dodgy red card assessed to the american team in their round of 32 win—they hardly want (or needed) the "help," inserting unwelcome politics into what's been a tremendous run.

as for me, i celebrated america's 250th in nantucket. a declaration of independence reading, a pie eating contest, a massive water fight on main street, and no left-right politics in sight :)

yours truly,  
ian

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